

SHAKESH RAVAL



Terror in the Woods

The spectre of extremism looms over the virgin forests of Sabarkantha as armed tribals fell trees, threaten officials and take possession of forestland at the incitement of ultra activists

■ By Uday Mahurkar

The verdant Polo jungles of Vijaynagar in north Gujarat's Sabarkantha district have a substantial population of tribals, but unlike many other tribal areas in the country that reel under poverty, malnourishment, sickness and violence, there are signs of prosperity here. Medieval temples and buildings dot the reserve forests—a habitat of leopards, sloth bear, rare cats and birds—that have become an eco-tourism destination. Pucca roads crisscross the forests and the state Government's Jyotigram scheme ensures that every village gets 24-hour domestic power supply, affording tribals the opportunity to pursue

various vocations sitting at home. Thanks to development programmes over the last few years, the lot of the locals has improved exponentially.

But now it looks like the dreaded flames of extremism are set to enter this virgin territory. Recently, a mob of about 600 tribal men and women armed with bows and arrows, pickaxes and swords forcibly took possession of forestland by felling 6,000-8,000 trees, some dating back a 100 years. They also mounted an attack on the local Forest Department office to free six of their activists, who had been arrested for deforestation. Officials were injured and two tribals were killed in retaliatory police firing. The police have charged 26 tribals, but less than a dozen have been arrested so far.

At the root of the tribal unrest is the Backward and Minority Communities' Employees Federation (BAMCEF), an all-India outfit with moorings in Maharashtra, whose operations remain secretive. According to villagers, BAMCEF activists have been inciting violence by preaching that tribals are the original inhabitants of the forests and therefore should throw out all non-tribals. Ramesh Dita Ninama of Kherwada village, a top BAMCEF activist who has been arrested in connection with the tree-felling and the attack on the forest office, is said to be among the prime instigators. Ninama has a notorious record and has been brought to book on charges of encroachment earlier.

Says Mavaji Katara, former